



Figure 1: The XBMC interface

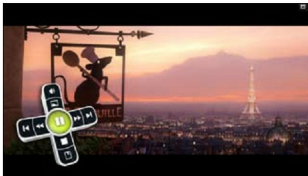


Figure 2: XBMC playing an HD movie

- Driver: ATI Catalyst 9.6 used in all OSs

The XBMC Media Centre, formerly the Xbox Media Centre, started as a two-man army under the name of Xbox Media Player. Initially restrained to Xbox consoles, the project came to an end on December 13, 2003 and was succeeded by the highly acclaimed XBMC Media Centre, which had a team of almost 200 developers and translators working on it.

XBMC is built on the high-quality and complex OpenGL interface written in C++. Despite being a media centre application, XBMC lacks rudimentary media centre features like support for PVR recording and TV guides, which is a serious let down for any media centre application. Although it offers similar features with the help of third-party plug-ins, this is never a very reliable solution.

Prerequisites

XBMC is a very resource-demanding application due to the highly complex OpenGL implementation it comes with. The website doesn't provide the system requirements for the application but it is advisable to have a 2 GHz or above CPU, 2GB RAM and a decent graphics card with Open GL support. Though in my rig, I had no problem with the player except for some annoying bugs that hindered executing the program.

Make sure you install all the proprietary graphics drivers before using it. Users planning to run Blue-ray or HD movies should have a 3 GHz multi-core CPU or a GPU capable of hardware acceleration.

Installation notes

- You can get the latest Ubuntu builds from the Ubuntu PPA at <http://launchpad.net/~team-xbmc/+archive/ppa>. In order to install, first select the Ubuntu version you have and generate the repository from the above link. Navigate to *GNOME menu* → *System* → *Administration* → *Software Sources*. Under the 'Third Party Software' tab, add the main and source repositories. Once done, you need to add the security keyring for XBMC—copy everything from <http://keyserver.ubuntu.com:11371/pks/lookup?op=get&search=0x6D975C4791E7EE5E> and save it as a normal text file. Back to the *Software Sources* window, under the 'Authenticate' tab, add the text file and reload repositories. Now, search for xbmc using Synaptic and install it.
- Mandriva users need to add a new repository: Mandriva Italian Backports (MIB). You can install MIB repositories from <http://mib.planetalinux.org/mib/repository.html>. Select the Mandriva version and CPU architecture, copy-paste the commands in a terminal as the root and you are good to go. Search for XBMC and install it. Note that you will have to install some extra packages in order to make XBMC run without throwing fits or aborting automatically. Open a terminal and type the following commands as the super user: `urpmi -a curl curl-devel`.
- openSUSE users need to enable Packman repositories. Add the repositories from http://en.opensuse.org/Additional_YaST_Package_Repositories#Packman or you can directly download xbmc packages from packman website <http://packman.links2linux.org/package/XBMC>.
- If you have the latest versions of Sabayon and Dreamlinux, XBMC will come pre-installed. Dreamlinux XFCE users need to install XBMC from a binary file located at www.dreamlinux.com.br/download.html.

Once installed, XBMC should launch without a problem.

With the system resources out of the way, it's time to figure out the installation source. Unlike the Xbox media player (its previous version), XBMC is available for almost all operating systems. It is available for Xbox consoles, Linux, Windows, MacOS, Apple TV and as a live CD. You can also grab the latest build from SVN and compile it if packages are not available for your distro.

Although it lists Linux as a supported OS, it only provides packages for Ubuntu. I will try to cover the installation in brief, but if packages are not available for your OS, then you will have to resort to compiling from source. Fortunately, many distros provide packages for XBMC or they ship it as the main media centre application. Here are some of the distros that